the boldness of daredevil militants and ineptness of intelligence agencies and weak will of the government to pursue and neutralise these elements.

On 25 June 2013, Ehsanullah Ehasan was removed from his position of the spokesperson of TTP due to his statement that Afghan Taliban and the TTP were two different entities and movements. Ehsan had told a local newspaper that the US–Taliban peace talks in Doha would have no effect on the TTP. His dismissal was announced through the distribution of a pamphlet by militants in North Waziristan, which said that 'He has made comments that raised the danger of divisions between the Pakistani Taliban and the Afghan Taliban'. 'The Taliban are our foundation and (Afghan Taliban leader) Mullah Omar is our supreme leader. That is why, from today, Ehsanullah Ehsan is no longer our spokesman.'

Ehsan's dismissal was considered one of the growing signs of divisions within the militant groups operating in the country's tribal regions and was seen as a move meant to appease the Afghan Taliban, who were referred to as their ideological bulwark by the Pakistani Taliban (*The Express Tribune*, 2013).

Ehsanullah was replaced by Shahidullah Shahid as the new spokesperson of TTP. According to sources, Ehsanullah Ehsan and Shahidullah Shahid were not their real names. Their real identity was concealed, though Ehsanullah appeared in videos too.

On rare occasions, the TTP chief personally met media people. One such occasion was when Hakimullah Mehsud gave an interview to the BBC to explain his stance on the much-hyped negotiations with the government of Pakistan on 9 October 2013 (BBC Urdu, 2013). For this interview, the TTP activists escorted Reuters to the remote area in Waziristan and ordered them not to disclose the exact location of the interview (*The News International*, 2013).

In rare cases, the TTP spokesperson talked to the government officers too to threaten them or to convince them to desist from anti-TTP activities. Shahidullah Shahid had a 20-minute talk with SSP Chaudhry Aslam, who was later killed by the TTP in a bomb blast in Karachi. Ch. Aslam was known for his risky actions against the TTP in Karachi that resulted in the arrests and killings of many TTP militants and facilitators. 'I had almost 20 minute conversation with Ch. Aslam in which I had conveyed to him our (TTP) message that we would avenge the killing of almost 60 fellows who were killed extra-judicially,' said